

The expansion of the US

After the Thirteen Colonies in British North America gained independence in 1783, many believed that their new nation was destined to expand across the continent. Land was stolen from Indigenous nations through war and treaties that were not upheld, or acquired from other European colonial powers.

Settlers rapidly expanded US territory westward from the east coast. The land they moved into was already occupied by Indigenous peoples, who endured great losses of life as they fought hard to protect their territory and lifestyles. But they were overcome by soldiers and settlers with superior firepower. Indigenous nations in the eastern US were forced to move from ancestral homelands into a designated “Indian Territory.” Many people died on the journey, which became known as the Trail of Tears (see p.173).

The discovery of gold in California in 1848 sparked a “gold rush” that attracted thousands more settlers to move to the west coast to make their fortunes, and the opening in 1869 of the first transcontinental railroad—connecting the Atlantic coast to the Pacific—drew in many more.

By 1898, the US had acquired its present shape, although not all the new lands immediately became states. Alaska and Hawaii, the final two territories to join the Union, were given statehood in 1959.

SACAGAWEA

An Indigenous American woman of the Shoshone nation, Sacagawea (c.1788–1812) scouted for explorers Meriwether Lewis and

William Clark between 1803 and 1806.

She translated local languages, prepared medicines, and helped them to establish contacts. She could not have foreseen that her actions would disrupt many Indigenous people’s ways of living as settlers began to expand across the continent.



◀ LOUISIANA PURCHASE

In 1803, President Thomas Jefferson bought the Louisiana Territory from France, doubling the size of the US. This purchase had not been approved by the Indigenous American nations. He then sent Meriwether Lewis and William Clark—whose compass is shown here—on an expedition to explore it all.

SETTLING THE LAND ▶

A series of trails built by pioneers across the US led settlers to a new life in the west. People took all their belongings with them in horse-drawn covered wagons, traveling together in long convoys for safety. Some went to farm new lands, others to find work.

